

Patriarch on the OFFENSIVE

With the Opposition in disarray and his party on a winning spree, a combative Karunanidhi has disarmed his rivals and made his ally, the Congress, insecure

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Photographs by HK RAJASHEKAR

The new twist in the Dravidian political plot only adds to the enigmatic opacity of its protagonist in dark glasses. At 86 and still a master in his game, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M. Karunanidhi knows how to keep the suspense intact. When he shared the dais with his counterpart from neighbouring Karnataka, B.S. Yeddyurappa, a rising regional star in the BJP, on two occasions—one at Bangalore at the unveiling of the statue of Tamil sage Thiruvalluvar and the other in Chennai at the inauguration of Kannada poet Sarvagana's statue—the camaraderie between the two was too conspicuous to be missed. Was he sending out a subtle message to the Congress, an ally in the state and at the Centre, that he can no longer be taken for granted? Was he making it clearer that when it comes to survival, he suffers from no saffron-phobia? After all, there is only one big agenda left now, and that is the smooth succession of M.K. Stalin. The patriarch—as foxy as ever—wants his son to inherit a politically safe state. And after the August 21 by-election results in which the DMK-Congress alliance won all the five seats (DMK 3, Congress 2), he has every reason to be combative.

The party has been on a winning spree since the 2006 Assembly elections; it has won every by-election and swept the general elections as well. Money, muscle and populist measures like Re 1 for a kg of rice and free television helped the DMK look invincible. Still, Karunanidhi is not one who lets his guard down when he tastes



KARUNANIDHI (RIGHT)
WITH SON STALIN

The chief minister will go to any extent to consolidate the powers of the heir apparent.